

**AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP
MELBOURNE, 18 January 2011**

Report by Nigel Nettheim

nettheim (at) bigpond.net.au



Solving in progress in the main room. Stephen Solomon is almost recognizable on the farthest board, with hands to chin. Under 12 and under 18 papers were placed on alternate boards where possible. NN is ready to answer questions. Photo courtesy of Raelene Zelesco.



Solving in progress in the overflow venue on the stage of the school's auditorium. Andrew Ballam (off camera) is ready to answer questions. Photo courtesy of Raelene Zelesco.



Marking in progress. Doug Hamilton (right, three times Australian Champion) and NN marking papers on a beautiful day at Dromana, a southern suburb of Melbourne. Photo courtesy of Dawn Nettheim.



Prize-giving concluded. NN presents Bobby Cheng with the first prize. Photo courtesy of Raelene Zelesco.

1. This was the fifth year of the problem-solving event, following Canberra 2007, Sydney 2008, Adelaide 2009 and Hobart 2010. Reports on earlier events can be seen at <http://OzProblems.com>.

2. The number of junior solvers was 77 (up from 62 last year). The playing tournaments were run in different ranges of days: January 15th-17th (65 players), 19th-23rd (93 players) and 15th-23rd (48 players). So there is no clear answer to the question what percentage of players entered the solving on the rest day, 18th. It is considered a good turn-out. The entry fee was \$10, as last year. In addition, 5 adults participated, the same number as last year (here one should bear in mind that many of the adults associated with the tournament naturally value their rest day as such).

3. Each solver was provided with a board and men. Many were provided with a clock which could be set to two hours, but I think few used it.

4. The time taken was noted when each question sheet was returned, to be used if needed to break ties. It was scarcely needed this time, as also in previous events. It might seem that the timing could be dispensed with, but it is important to make sure that Champions can be determined, ties not being acceptable (playoffs are held to break ties in the playing events). Few competitors left particularly early, and quite a large number stayed for the whole two hours.

5. The solutions, with diagrams, are included at the end of this file. I also have spare hard-copies of the question papers that may be requested.

6. My article entitled "A Quick Introduction to Chess Problems and End-game Studies", which I had originally prepared for the 2007 Championship, was made available on the present Championship's web site. Just before solving started, I asked competitors whether they had read that article, and this time a fair proportion had. The article is of some value in making sure that all competitors know in advance what problems and studies are, and that they have been exposed to a suitable introduction to them, with examples. Before solving started I also explained what "Mate in 2 moves" means, because not all entrants may have been familiar with the term.

7. The format of the question sheet continues to work well: a single A3 sheet folded over to take up A4 size, with only the instructions on the front page so that the sheet could be placed unopened on the tables in advance.

8. During the solving period, Andrew Ballam and I acted as invigilators and were available to answer questions from the competitors. Only a few questions were asked, the most common being how many moves need be written down, especially for studies (the answer is given on the front page of the question sheet).

9. The listing of entrants on marking sheets by age and gender (quite a time-consuming task) was carried out by Andrew Ballam and myself. Marking was carried out by Doug Hamilton and myself. We each marked each answer independently on marking sheets prepared in advance as blank sheets. The marking was completed in time for the presentations on the last day of the championships. A very few errors, generally of a clerical nature, by each marker were resolved. The two markings differed very little generally, but small differences of partial

credit were allowed to remain in cases where they could not affect prizes. It is very valuable to have the two independent markers, in ensuring clerical accuracy, in resolving matters of judgment, and in providing confidence to the competitors and their parents. The constant number of marks per task (10) worked well (total marks for each paper was 120).

10. It may be worth while pointing out that the running of a direct-mate solving competition is relatively straightforward. The running of an endgame study solving competition is much less straightforward. In the selection of studies one should keep in mind straight-forward marking (no unclear or arguable lines). The selection of studies suitable for our purpose is not easy and is very time-consuming.

11. The markers' job is assumed to be finished when the total marks have been reported in each of the 12 age-group/gender sections. Then the tournament organizers apply a method of determining prizes according to their desired scheme (revised from last year's scheme which seemed to have some disadvantages.) The markers have a role to play in breaking ties and in recommending any special awards.

12. The list of prize-winners is available on the Championship web site at <http://ajcc2011.com.au> (click on Results). Many prizes were presented, including medals, six subscriptions to Australasian Chess kindly donated by Brian Jones, and three books kindly donated by Marcus Raine. All entry fees were utilised, for no profit was desired.

13. Very many thanks indeed are offered to Geoff Foster for once again carrying out the time-consuming expert job of setting the tasks and preparing the papers and solutions for printing. I collaborated a little here, solving the proposed tasks.

14. The question of the number of separate papers to be set could still be discussed. However, the present two papers, one for U18/U16/U14 and another for U12/U10/U8, with some overlap of tasks, seems to work quite well.

15. Adults were invited, as last time. Five took part, including again Stephen Solomon, a former Australian Champion across the board, who was in Melbourne as a coach. He again scored 100%, this time in only 50 minutes. The notable chess problem composer Linden Lyons (see recent issues of the "Problem Potpourri" section of the Australasian Chess magazine) also took part, scoring full marks for the direct-mate tasks.

16. The general impression from their comments was that competitors enjoyed the event. The administrators also seemed very satisfied with it. It has been reported that parents like the "examination" atmosphere of the event, making it seem somewhat similar to school exams and thus suggesting that chess is not just a matter of their children playing games – an unforeseen favourable effect.

17. Again the influence of coaches in promoting problem-solving was noticeable, and is to be encouraged. Even composition has occasionally been attempted by juniors, and is a long-term goal of the solving activity.

Some Statistics of the Marks (Please see the Tables below.)

18. As always, our policy has been not to release individual results. The reasons for this include the following: (i) No disparagement was ever intended towards those scoring low marks, especially as some may never have seen a formal problem or endgame study before. (ii) Requests for revision might lead to prolonged correspondence for which there simply isn't time, and the marking has already been done with all care (see paragraph 9). (iii) In cases where it was already clear that prizes would not be affected, less attention might be given to the awarding of partial credit or the resolving of small differences between markers, as a purely practical matter.

19. The marks scored have meaning only in relation to the particular tasks set and their difficulty, so that comparisons from year to year, or to school-work exams, would not be valid. Comparisons between the two columns of Table 2 also have little meaning, except for the tasks in common to the two papers, mentioned later. Comparisons could be made within any one Championship event between playing and solving results, and a fairly close correlation has been informally observed. The relationship between the percentage marks scored and the difficulty as estimated in advance (according to the ordering of the tasks throughout the papers) was observed to a fair extent (see Table 2). Any tendency for endgame studies to be solved more easily or less easily than direct-mate problems could only be investigated informally; this year the direct mates received higher marks than the studies in both papers, but the relative difficulty of the tasks selected would have to be taken into account.

Best wishes for the future!

Nigel Nettheim, 22 March 2011.

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Table 1. Number of Competitors, in each Age Group and each Gender

Age	U8	U10	U12	U14	U16	U18	Adult	Total
Male	8	9	19	12	4	9	4	65
Female	0	4	6	1	3	2	1	17
Total	8	13	25	13	7	11	5	82

Those U8, U10 and U12 took the U12 paper (except that one took both papers). Those U14, U16 and U18 and the adults took the U18 paper. The female groups were combined for prize purposes into U8+U10, U12+U14 and U16+U18.

Scores (see Table 2)

The average scores were U18/U16/U14: 27%, U12/U10/U8: 29%. The averages last year were 53% and 54% respectively. One reason for the lower scores this year was that our “gift” tasks had been rather easier last year. Other factors such as the proportion of novices taking part may have played a part. And in general the tasks were harder this year, as far as one can judge this somewhat personal matter. That was partly in response to the fact that the top solvers had found the papers too easy last year. There is a very wide range of solving abilities – to some solvers these tasks are of a kind they have never seen before, while a few solvers are real experts in this area. It is attempted to set a good challenge for the top solvers while at the same time allowing the novices to feel some satisfaction at successfully solving a few tasks. To get a good balance between these extremes is not easy. It seems that next year at least one very difficult task should be set for the top solvers, at least one very easy one for novices, and the other tasks fairly easy, between those extremes. That has always been the aim, but we will hope to achieve it better next year. From the competitive point of view (determining prize-winners), the level of difficulty of the tasks set is not vital but, as mentioned, it is good to give plenty of satisfaction to the solvers.

The same two solvers who obtained 100% last year did so again this year: Stephen Solomon (adult) in 50 min., and Bobby Cheng (age 13), in 70 min (of 120 min. available). And Yi Yuan (age 15) missed only one solution. Thus the papers, though too hard for the majority, were, as mentioned above, too easy at the highest level.

Table 2. Percent of Total Marks Scored, for each Task on each Paper

Results for males and females are combined here, excluding Adults. The task diagrams are shown at the end of this report. Equal marks are obtainable for each task, and each cell shows the percent of these awarded for the particular task. The same task in different sections is indicated by [*] etc.

	U12/U10/U8		U18/U16/14	
	Task	%	Task	%
1	#2 Dehler 1.Bh2	64	#2 Kovacevic... 1.Bd4 [*]	34
2	#2 A.H. 1.Qd8	44	Win Gerbtsman [**] 1.Ke3...6.h8=R	36
3	Win Kuzmanovic 1.Rg8+	31	#2 Marin 1.e5	29
4	#2 Lincoln 1.Rb4	57	Win Pogosyants 1.f6xe7	23
5	Win Gerbtsman [**] 1.Ke3 & 6.h8=R	20	#2 Harley [***] 1.Ra5	43
6	Win Mitrofanov... 1.Rg1 (simplified)	15	Draw Smyslov [****] 1.g4	32
7	#2 Kovacevic...[*] 1.Bd4	23	#2 Ahues 1.Nc6	24
8	Draw Smyslov [****] 1.g4	5	Win Mitrofanov... 1.Rg1 (not simplified)	23
9	#2 Harley [***] 1.Ra5	23	#2 Baumgartner 1.Qf1	20
10	Win Pogosyants 1.Ke2	32	Win Cook... 1.Kb8	13
11	#2 Speckmann 1.Re4	35	#3 Whyatt 1.h6	26
12	Win Pogosyants 1.b7	7	#Draw Pogosyants 1.Bc4+ & 6.Bd5	21
	Total (100%)	29	Total (100%)	27

Averages over each whole paper:
 U18/U16/U14 Girls 17%, Boys 31%
 U12/U10/U8 Girls 18%, Boys 33%.

A few comments on the individual tasks:

The U12 paper (meaning here U12/U10/U8):

U12 No. 1. As in previous years, we tried to make sure that everyone had the satisfaction of finding at least one solution; this time our “gift”, though receiving the highest marks of all the tasks, was not quite as easy as last year’s.

U12 No. 2. Relatively well solved, though not quite as easily as was intended.

U12 No. 3. Again found a bit harder than expected.

U12 No. 4. Relatively well solved

U12 No. 5. Few solvers found the underpromotion. Partial credit of 3/10 was awarded without it, a fairly low mark in order to reward properly those who did find it.

U12 No. 6. Most found the first two moves, but few found the stalemate defence.

U12 No. 7. Not found particularly easy.

U12 No. 8. Found the hardest of the 12 tasks. A simplified version of a study by Smyslov, a former World Champion who had died in the past year.

U12 No. 9. An amusing position of the White pieces; found difficult.

U12 No. 10. Partial credit was given for the try 1.a7 etc.

U12 No. 11. Quite well solved, considering that it was assumed to be fairly difficult.

U12 No. 12. The stalemate defence was not often found.

Perhaps many of the youngest solvers were not yet very familiar with stalemate, which seldom arises in their games. But stalemate plays a prominent role in endgame studies, a point which coaches might like to mention, along with underpromotion.

The U18 paper (meaning here U18/U16/U14):

U18 No. 1 = U12 No. 7. Not particularly easy.

U18 No. 2. = U12 No. 5. Few noticed the stalemate defence.

U18 No. 3. Again not particularly easy.

U18 No. 4. Found quite difficult, which we had not expected.

U18 No. 5. = U12 No. 9.

U18 No. 6. = U12 No. 8.

U18 No. 7. Found not easy.

U18 No. 8. The final move is well-hidden and was not often found; partial credit was often given.

U18 No. 9. Found the most difficult mate in 2, as expected.

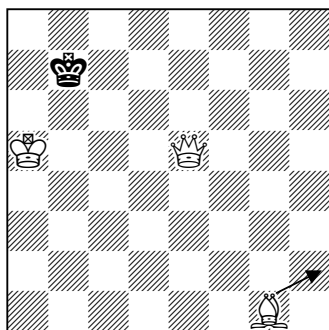
U18 No. 10. Composed especially for this event, and found the hardest task. Subsequently published in "Problem Potpourri" in Australasian Chess, March 2011.

U18 No. 11. A good mate in 3 and not particularly difficult.

U18 No.12. Found difficult, as expected. A well-hidden stalemate defence and a surprising last move of White.

The four tasks in common between the two papers had scores (23, 34), (20, 36), (23, 43), (5, 32), confirming the (not always huge) advantage of age.

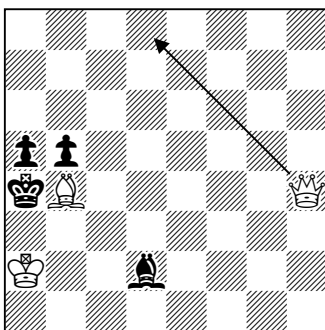
AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP MELBOURNE 2011 UNDER 12/10/8 SOLUTIONS



Number 1.
White to play and mate in 2

O. Dehler,
Deutsche Schachzeitung, 1923

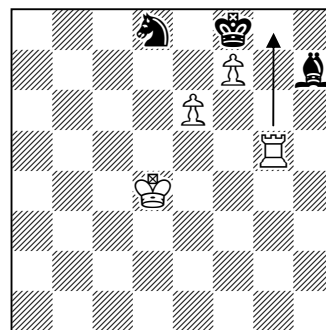
1. Qh2! (waiting)
 1. ... Kc6 2. Qb5
 1. ... Kc8 2. Qc7
 1. ... Ka7 2. Qb8
 1. ... Ka8 2. Qb8



Number 2.
White to play and mate in 2

A. H., *Reynold's Miscellany*,
1868

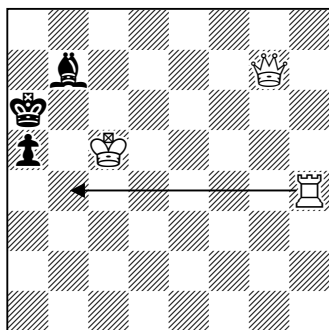
1. Qd8! (threat 2. Qxa5)
 1. ... Kxb4 2. Qd4
 1. ... Bxb4 2. Qd1
 1. ... Kxb4 2. Qa8



Number 3.
White to play and Win

based on a study by Kuzmanovic

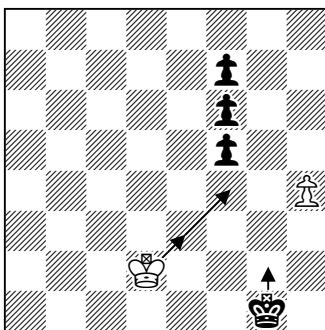
1. Bg8+! Bxg8
 2. Ae7+! wins



Number 4.
White to play and mate in 2

R. Lincoln, *Fun With Chess
Miniatures*, 1996

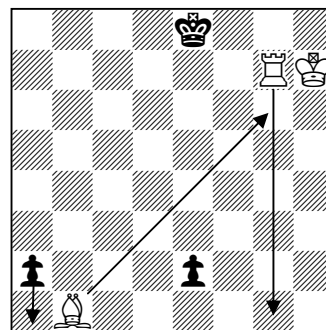
- Try: 1. Bg7? Ka4!
 1. Bb4! (threat 2. Qxb7)
 1. ... B any 2. Bb6
 1. ... Ka4 2. Bxa4
 1. ... Kxb4 2. Qa1
 1. ... Ka7 2. Qxb7



Number 5.
White to play and Win

Alexandre I. Gerbstman,
L'Echiquier, 1928

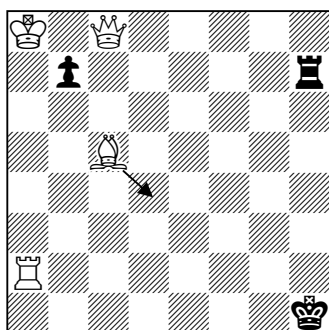
1. Qe3 Kg2 (or Qh2)
 2. Qf4 Qh3
 3. Ah5 Qh4
 4. Ah6 Qh5
 5. Ah7 Qg6
 6. Ah8=Q!



Number 6.
White to play and Win

L. A. Mitrofanov & E. L.
Pogosyants,
3 Prize, Lokker Mem., 1974
(simplified version)

1. Bg1 Ka1=Q
 2. Qg6+ Qf8!
 3. Bxa1 Ke1=Q
 4. Ba8+ Qe7
 5. Be8+ wins



Number 7.
White to play and mate in 2

M. Kovacevic & M. Subotic,
3 comm., *The Problemist*, 1992

Try: 1. ♖b6? ♜d7!

Try: 1. ♜d8? ♜e7!

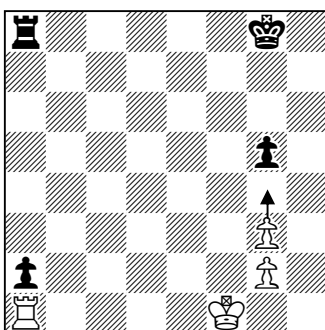
Try: 1. ♜e8? ♜f7!

Try: 1. ♜f8? ♜g7!

1. ♖d4! (threat 2. ♜c1)

1. ... ♜h8 2. ♜xh8

1. ... ♜c7 etc. 2. ♜h3



Number 8.
White to play and Draw

based on a study by Smyslov

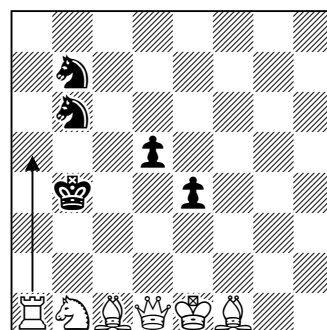
1. ♖g4 ♜f7

2. ♖g3 ♜e6

3. ♜g2 ♜d5

4. ♜h3 ♜c4

5. ♜x2! ♜x2 stalemate



Number 9.
White to play and mate in 2

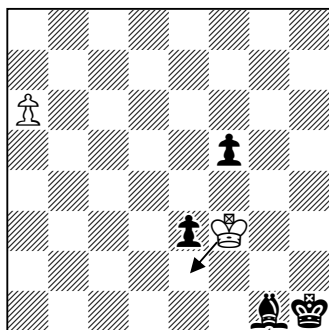
B Harley, *Observer*, 1926

1. ♜a5! (threats 2. ♜b5 and ♖d2)

1. ... ♜xa5 2. ♖d2

1. ... ♜xa5 2. ♖a3

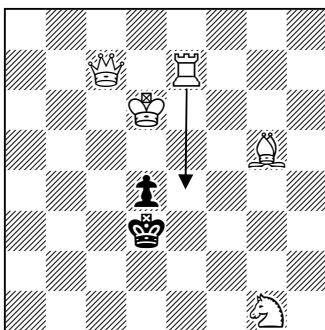
1. ... ♜c4 2. ♜a4



Number 10.
White to play and Win
E L Pogosyants,
Shakhmaty v SSSR, 1977

1. ♜e2! ♜f4
2. ♖a7 ♜f3+
3. ♜xf3 ♜e2
4. ♖a8=♜ ♜e1=♜
5. ♜g4+ ♜h2
6. ♜h8+ ♜g2
7. ♜h3+ ♜f2
8. ♜f3 mate

(1. ♖a7? ♜e2
2. ♖a8=♜ ♜e1=♜
3. ♜f4+ ♜e4+ draw)

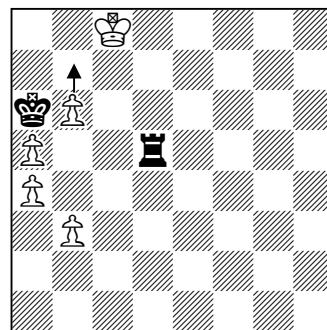


Number 11.
White to play and mate in 2

W. Speckmann,
Europe Echecs, 1964

1. ♜e4! ♜xe4

2. ♜h7



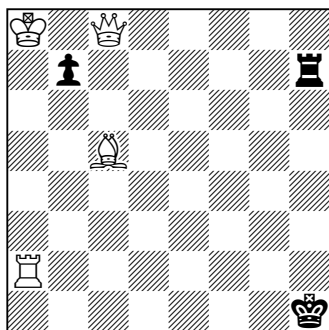
Number 12.
White to play and Win

E L Pogosyants, 1 HM,
Shakhmatnaya Moskva, 1961
(version)

1. ♖b7 ♜c5+
2. ♜b8 ♜h5
3. ♜a8 ♜h8+
4. ♖b8=♜! wins

(4. ♖b8=♜? ♜d8!
5. ♖b4 (5. ♜xd8 stalemate)
5. ... ♜xb8+
6. ♜xb8 stalemate)

**AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP MELBOURNE 2011
UNDER 18/16/14 SOLUTIONS**

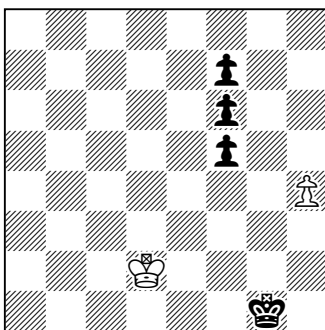


Number 1.
White to play and mate in 2

M. Kovacevic & M. Subotic,
3 comm., *The Problemist*, 1992

Try: 1. ♖b6? but ♜d7!
Try: 1. ♜d8? but ♜e7!
Try: 1. ♜e8? but ♜f7!
Try: 1. ♜f8? but ♜g7!

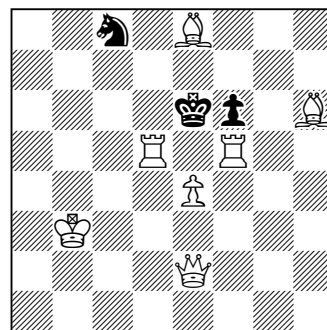
1. ♖d4! (threat 2. ♜c1)
1. ... ♜d7 2. ♜c1
1. ... ♜h8 2. ♜xh8
1. ... ♜c7 etc. 2. ♜h3



Number 2.
White to play and Win

Alexandre I Gerbstman,
L'Echiquier, 1928

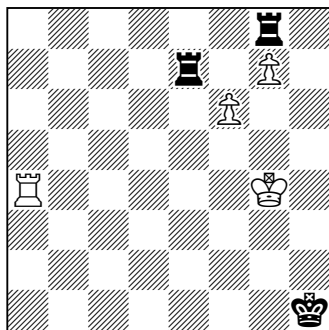
1. ♖e3 ♜g2
2. ♜f4 ♜h3
3. ♜h5 ♜h4
4. ♜h6 ♜h5
5. ♜h7 ♜g6
6. ♜h8=♚!



Number 3.
White to play and mate in 2

V. Marin,
Boys' Own Paper, 1892

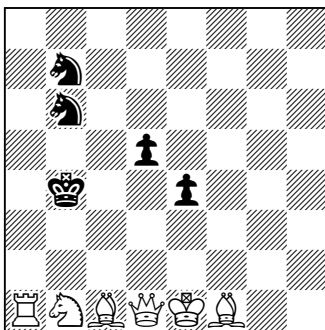
1. ♜e5! (threat 2. ♜xf6)
1. ... ♜xf5 2. ♜e6
1. ... ♜xd5 2. ♜c4
1. ... ♜e7 2. ♜xf6
1. ... ♜xe5 2. ♜xe5
1. ... ♜d6 2. ♜xd6



Number 4.
White to play and Win

E L Pogosyants, 1-5 Prize,
Kazantsev JT, 1976 (version)

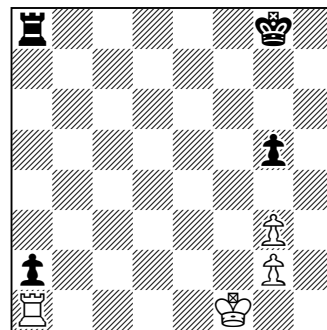
1. ♜xe7 ♜xg7+
2. ♜h3 ♜h7+
3. ♜g3 ♜g7+
4. ♜f2 ♜f7+
5. ♜f4! ♜xf4+
6. ♜e3 ♜f1
7. ♜e2 (or ♜d2) wins



Number 5.
White to play and mate in 2

B Harley, *Observer*, 1926

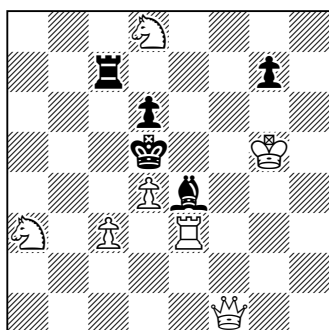
1. ♜a5! (threats 2. ♜b5 and ♜d2)
1. ... ♜xa5 2. ♜d2
1. ... ♜xa5 2. ♜a3
1. ... ♜c4 2. ♜a4



Number 6.
White to play and Draw

based on a study by Smyslov

1. ♜g4 ♜f7
2. ♜g3 ♜e6
3. ♜g2 ♜d5
4. ♜h3 ♜c4
5. ♜xa2! ♜xa2 stalemate



Number 7.
White to play and mate in 2

H Ahues, 3 Prize,
idée & form, 2002/03

Try: 1. ♖b5? (threat 2. ♖×c7)

1. ... ♜ file 2. ♜f7

1. ... ♜ rank 2. ♜c4

but 1... ♜d3!

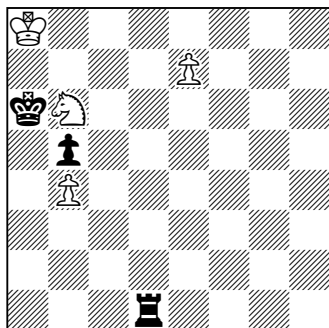
1. ♖c6! (threat 2. ♜c4)

1. ... ♜×c6 2. ♜b5

1. ... ♜e6 2. ♜f5

1. ... ♜×c6 2. ♜f7

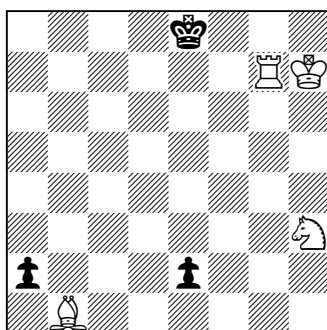
1. ... ♜d3 2. ♖b4



Number 10.
White to play and Win

Roger Cook & Nigel Nettheim,
to be published in *Australasian Chess*, March 2011

1. ♜b8 (1. ♜e8=♜? ♜d8+;
1. ♖c8? ♜d8! 2. ♜b8 ♜d7 for
3... ♜b7+ 4. ♜a8 ♜b8+) ♜d7
2. ♖d5 (2. ♖c8? ♜b7+ 3. ♜a8
♜b8+) ♜×d5 3. ♜e8=♜!
(3. ♜e8=♜? ♜d8+ draw) ♜d6
4. ♜c7 wins



Number 8.
White to play and Win

L A Mitrofanov & E L
Pogosyants,
3 Prize, Lokker Mem., 1974

1. ♜g1 ♜a1=♜

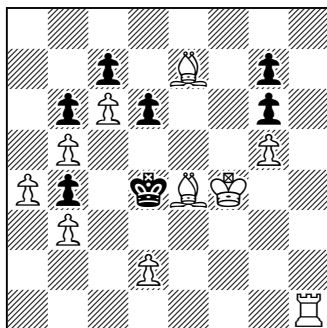
2. ♖g6+ ♜f8!

3. ♜×a1 ♜e1=♜

4. ♜a8+ ♜e7

5. ♜e8+ ♜f6

6. ♖f2! wins



Number 11.
White to play and mate in 3

W.A. Whyatt, *Weekly Times*
(Melbourne), 1953

Set play

1. ... ♜c5 2. ♜c1+ ♜d4 3. ♜c4

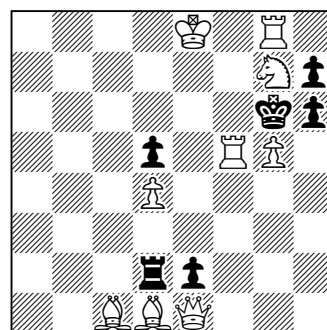
1. ... ♜d5 2. ♜h8 ♜×e4 3. ♜d8

1. ♜h6! waiting

1. ... ♜c5 2. ♜e3 ♜×h6 3. ♜d4

1. ... ♜×h6 2. ♖f6+ ♜c5 3. ♜d4

1. ... ♜d5 2. ♜h8 ♜×e4 3. ♜d8



Number 9.
White to play and mate in 2

G Baumgartner, commended,
The Sun Herald, 1961

Try: 1. ♜e7? ♜h5!

Try: 1. ♖c2? ♜×g5!

Try: 1. ♜×d5? ♜×d4!

1. ♜f1! waiting

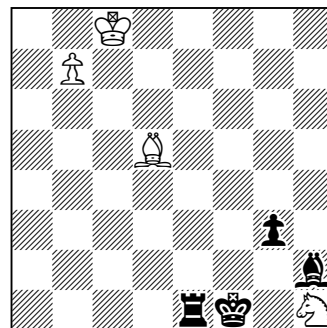
1. ... ♜×d1=♜ 2. ♜a6

1. ... ♜e1=♜+ 2. ♖e6

1. ... ♜×f1=♜ 2. ♖h5

1. ... ♜h5 2. ♖e6

1. ... ♜×g5 2. ♜f6



Number 12.
White to play and Draw

E L Pogosyants, *Shakhmaty*, 1962

1. ♖c4+ ♜g1

2. ♜b8=♜ ♜e8+

3. ♜b7 ♜×b8+

4. ♜×b8 ♜g2+

5. ♜c8! ♜×h1=♜

6. ♖d5! ♜×d5 stalemate